

## Teaching Statement

My goal as a political science teacher is not simply to convey theories and facts, but to equip students with the tools to analyze political events independently. At the University of Pittsburgh, I have put this philosophy into practice as a teaching assistant for *Research Methods in Political Science* and *Introduction to International Relations*, leading recitation sections that combined hands-on laboratories, simulations, group discussions, and collaborative exercises. I have also delivered guest lectures in *Research Methods in Political Science*, *Authoritarian Politics*, and *Civil Wars* on refugee return, the security implications of forced migration, and civilian responses to repression and armed conflict. These experiences have shaped a substantively grounded and practice-based teaching approach: I connect theoretical and methodological training to contemporary political problems, make unfamiliar analytical tools accessible through active learning, and encourage students to evaluate critically both political claims and existing explanations.

### Teaching Philosophy, Experience, and Mentoring

My teaching experience at the University of Pittsburgh spans both research methodology and the substantive study of international relations. Across two semesters, I have led recitation sections, graded examinations and assignments, and held weekly office hours for courses enrolling more than 100 students. As a teaching assistant for *Research Methods in Political Science*, I led lab-based recitation sections that introduced students to foundational statistical methods, data processing, and programming in R. Because many undergraduates initially find mathematical concepts and programming unfamiliar or intimidating, I emphasized accessible explanations, collaborative learning, and substantive applications. I developed in-class problem sets that connected methodological concepts to contemporary political questions. For example, one exercise began with a broad question in international security: How has the Russia–Ukraine war affected European politics? Students then examined one concrete dimension of this question—government spending on defense. By analyzing changes in European countries’ military expenditures before and after Russia’s invasion of Ukraine, they practiced data merging, difference-in-means tests, statistical inference, and regression analysis.

This approach sustained student engagement and strengthened students’ ability to work collaboratively. More importantly, it helped them view data and statistics not as abstract mathematics or unfamiliar numbers, but as practical tools for investigating political events and evaluating empirical claims. To make methods courses more engaging, I also used unconventional datasets and playful programming exercises to demonstrate the appeal of data analysis and coding. In recitation problem sets, for example, I incorporated data on insurgent leaders’ spiritual practices and political attitudes expressed in popular music to show that quantitative methods can illuminate a wide range of substantive questions. During lab sessions, I introduced engaging R packages and functions that allowed students to generate drawings of small animals and simulate the infinite monkey theorem. These activities helped students discover enjoyment and curiosity in learning quantitative methods and programming.

During office hours, I encouraged students to identify additional real-world situations in which statistical concepts and programming skills could be applied. These conversations invited them to think beyond individual assignments and consider how methodological training could support their future coursework, professional development, and everyday interpretation of political information. By connecting technical skills to questions students already cared about, I sought to build both analytical competence and confidence.

As a teaching assistant for *Introduction to International Relations*, I adapted this practice-based approach to a substantively focused course. I led recitation sections that combined group discussions, simulations, and simplified model-based exercises to help students develop a systematic understanding of the field’s major theories and schools of thought. Students applied theoretical frameworks to issues including peacekeeping during civil wars, tariff disputes, and

military alliances. I also asked them to identify cases that existing theories could not fully explain, demonstrating how empirical anomalies can generate new research questions and theoretical puzzles.

To make complex international processes more analytically manageable, I introduced exercises that asked students to identify relevant actors, preferences, strategic choices, and potential outcomes. Event-labeling activities likewise encouraged them to distinguish among different forms of political behavior before drawing broader conclusions. These exercises helped students move beyond describing international events and toward constructing theoretically informed explanations. I also used simulations, debates, and analytical writing to encourage students to apply theories rather than simply memorize them. In one simulation of a trade dispute between two fictional countries, students worked in teams to decide whether to reveal or misrepresent their preferences, negotiate with the opposing side, and choose between compromise and tariff escalation. The exercise helped them understand concepts such as cheap talk, private information, and costly signaling by experiencing the strategic choices these concepts describe. Together, my experiences in these two courses taught me to adapt my pedagogy to different learning objectives, from developing quantitative and computational skills to facilitating theoretical discussion and critical engagement with contemporary political problems.

I have also integrated my research expertise in forced migration and civil conflict into guest lectures for both methodological and substantive courses. In *Civil Wars*, I drew on my dissertation research to deliver a lecture on the security implications of forced migration. I introduced students to different forms of displacement, the causes and consequences of forced migration, and the ways population movements can shape conflict escalation, the geographic diffusion of violence, and the international dimensions of civil war. In *Authoritarian Politics* and *Research Methods in Political Science*, I used Myanmar as a case study in lectures on civilian responses to government repression and conflict escalation. For each lecture, I prepared discussion prompts and collaborative exercises that connected the material to concepts students had previously encountered. Rather than presenting my research as a settled conclusion, I encouraged students to consider where its arguments and evidence supported, qualified, or challenged the theories they had studied.

Beyond the classroom, I am committed to mentoring early-stage graduate students and prospective students. Drawing on my own experiences with graduate applications and doctoral study, I have served as a peer mentor to incoming Ph.D. students in my department, offering guidance on course selection, research resources, conference participation, and program requirements at different stages of graduate training. I have also provided feedback on statements of purpose and writing samples for undergraduate and prospective graduate students, helping them articulate their research interests and present their academic preparation more effectively. Talented students may encounter unnecessary barriers because they lack access to information about application procedures, the informal expectations of graduate education, or the process of adjusting to doctoral study. Through mentoring, my aim is to help students articulate their ideas more clearly, make informed decisions about graduate training, and approach unfamiliar professional expectations with greater confidence.

### **Inclusive Teaching**

As an international scholar in the United States, I am attentive to the ways students' cultural, educational, and personal backgrounds shape how they participate in and experience the classroom. I am committed to creating an environment in which students feel respected, supported, and comfortable contributing their perspectives. At the University of Pittsburgh, I completed a semester-long University Teaching Practicum focused on course design, active-learning strategies, and inclusive pedagogy. This training helped me recognize how differences in identity, culture, prior preparation, and educational experience can affect students' learning and participation. Workshops offered by the Department of Political Science have further prepared me to respond thoughtfully to the needs of students with disabilities, military or veteran backgrounds, and

experiences of trauma.

I translate this training into concrete practices designed to reduce barriers both inside and outside the classroom. In lectures and recitation sections, I avoid unnecessary jargon and culture-specific idioms, define unfamiliar terms, and provide multiple ways for students to engage with the material. I also adapt the format of instruction when classroom conditions make slides or screens difficult to see, using the board, verbal explanation, or printed materials as appropriate. These adjustments help ensure that students can follow the course regardless of their linguistic background, prior familiarity with political science, or physical location in the classroom.

In methods courses, I am especially attentive to differences in students' prior exposure to mathematics, coding, and computer use. Before asking students to complete data-analysis exercises, I provide step-by-step guidance on organizing folders, downloading files, installing software, opening spreadsheets, and accessing or borrowing university computers. I also distribute concise reference sheets containing key formulas, coding commands, and calculation tips, and I build low-stakes practice into recitation sessions before assigning more demanding problem sets. These practices are intended not to lower expectations, but to make the path toward meeting them more transparent and accessible.

I also make students aware of relevant university resources at the beginning of the semester, including library support, disability services, mental-health resources, and academic assistance. When students require accommodations or additional support, I work with them and the appropriate university offices to identify effective and equitable ways for them to participate. Through clear communication, flexible instructional formats, and transparent expectations, I aim to create a classroom in which students from different backgrounds can engage meaningfully, develop confidence, and succeed academically.

### **Future Teaching Plans**

My graduate training and experience in teaching and research have prepared me to teach a wide range of courses in international relations and political methodology at both the undergraduate and graduate levels. At the undergraduate level, I am interested in teaching foundational courses such as *Introduction to International Relations* and *Introduction to Political Methodology*. My substantive expertise in civil conflict, humanitarian assistance, and forced displacement would also allow me to offer courses on *Civil War*, *Foreign Aid*, and *International Migration*. In these courses, I would help students develop a deeper understanding of contemporary political problems while encouraging them to formulate their own research questions and substantive interests.

At the graduate level, I would be prepared to teach introductory workshops or summer boot camps in mathematics, statistics, and data analysis for political science. I would also welcome the opportunity to teach advanced methods courses in causal inference, multilevel modeling, computational political science, and research design. My goal in these courses would be to help graduate students connect substantive research questions to appropriate analytical tools and develop the skills necessary to carry out independent research.

My research agenda would also enable me to offer graduate seminars in international relations and global governance, including courses on conflict processes, human rights, refugees and forced displacement, and global humanitarian governance. Drawing on my own experiences as a graduate student and peer mentor, I would provide structured guidance on developing a research puzzle, designing an empirical strategy, revising seminar papers for publication, and preparing for conference presentations. I would also seek opportunities to involve students in collaborative research when appropriate, helping them gain experience in moving from an initial question to a completed research project.